

Bluff Your Classmates Activity

Your job is to deceive your fellow classmates!

Within your group, read the stories presented to you on the back of this sheet. One of them depicts a real example of parenting behavior in the animal kingdom, while the other two are baloney. Your group's task is to:

- 1) Correctly identify the true animal behavior.
- 2) Find a way to convince your classmates that one of the false examples of behavior are the correct answer.

You will have a **15-minute** period to read your stories and collectively decide on the one you think is the truth. You are free to edit the false stories to make them seem more convincing or read them in an entertaining way to distract from the lie!

Afterwards, we will reconvene as a class. When it's your group's turn, read your stories aloud (preferably, each of you reads one). Your classmates will collectively decide which one they think is the true story.

Be careful that you are not deceived yourselves – you won't know what the true behavior is until we discuss this as a class!

Group 1

Story 1:

Spoiler alert! In the classic animated movie, *The Lion King*, Mufasa is king of a literal animal kingdom. His jealous brother, Scar, kills him to gain control over the kingdom. Power struggles like this actually happen in real lion groups, but the victims are often children, not adults. In lions, rival males have been seen attacking and killing the children of other males. It's understandable why the writers of the film chose to change things up a little.

Story 2:

When she is ready to lay her eggs, a mother sea turtle returns to the exact beach where she was born. After the eggs hatch, the mother turtle will guide her children from the beach to the nearest feeding grounds. In doing so, the baby sea turtles learn how to get navigate back to the beach where they were born. When they grow up, they too will return to their home beach and lay their eggs. This is why in some cultures; the sea turtle is a sacred symbol for sailors navigating the open sea.

Story 3:

Most bats live in huge colonies – one cave can contain thousands of bats. This can be troubling for bat mothers, since they must leave their infants behind to find food outside of the cave. When the mother returns, she must find her kid among thousands of others! Bats cannot recognize faces, but to find their children, they use the same tool they use to find food: sound. Mothers yell at specific frequency, and their children respond with the same one. Each parent and child have a unique frequency, making it easy to find each other.

Group 2

Story 1:

Is it being a good parent sexy? Some hummingbirds seem to think so. In hummingbirds, males provide parental care by fanning eggs with his wings. The nonstop fanning is tiring, but it keeps the eggs at an ideal temperature. Sometimes, other females will stop by to evaluate a male's parental ability. If they decide that he is a good fanner, they will mate with him. Hummingbird dads leave once the eggs hatch. Often, they will move on to fan the eggs of a female they mated with while watching another female's eggs!

Story 2:

Octopi are among the most intelligent creatures on Earth, but most species have remarkably short lives – no more than one year. Scientists recently discovered the reason: after mating, octopus parents “self-destruct!” We know more about this in females: after she lays her eggs, an octopus mom will deliberately stop eating, diligently protecting her clutch of eggs until she starves to death or is eaten by a predator. By the time the baby octopi emerge, their mother is most likely already dead.

Story 3:

Platypuses are weird enough – they are mammals but have beaks and webbed feet. They are also poisonous, can produce electricity, and can lay eggs. The ability to produce milk is one of the defining traits of mammals, but the platypus is unique in that manner too. Every female mammal has glands that produce milk for their children, but mother platypuses do not have those glands. That is the reason they lay eggs – they can only provide nutrients to their children through the contents of the egg.

Group 3

Story 1:

If you are born as a cuckoo bird, it pays to be early. A mother bird will lay multiple eggs in her nest. When the first chick hatches, the first thing on its mind is murder. Once out of its egg, the first cuckoo chick pushes its brothers' and sisters' eggs out of the nest. Its siblings fall to their deaths, and the first chick now gets to have mom's attention for itself.

Story 2:

Pelicans have long been a symbol of motherhood and good parenting. When feeding her chicks, a mother pelican will use her beak to injure herself. She then uses the blood from her wound to feed her babies. This act of self-sacrifice is prominently seen on many symbols around the world, including the flag of the US state of Louisiana.

Story 3:

Gifting your partner an engagement ring is a well-known pre-wedding ritual in humans, but other animals give their mates "engagement gifts" as well! A classic example is seen in the bush cricket: males produce a large balloon and fill it with nutritious sperm. When trying to impress a female, the male presents this gift to her. If accepted, the female will eat the gift and mate with the male.

Group 4

Story 1:

Dragonflies are the animal kingdom's biggest mama's boys (and girls). Adult dragonflies mate in mid-air, using a graceful flying dance. The mother dragonfly then lays eggs and keeps them attached to her tail. When the eggs hatch, the dragonfly nymphs stay fastened to their mother, absorbing nutrients through her body. When the nymphs grow wings, they detach from their mother and go on their own way. As one of nature's most beautiful flying creatures, it is fitting that dragonflies stay in the air from cradle to grave.

Story 2:

If you have siblings, your parents might have tried very hard not to pick a favorite child. Unfortunately, some animals are blatant about picking favorites. Baby birds beg for food from their mothers by chirping – chicks that need more food will beg louder and more often. In good times, mama birds give more food to the chicks that beg more – because they need it. However, when resources are scarce, mothers will give less food to loudly begging chicks. Sometimes, they will ignore them completely and let them die!

Story 3:

Large-mouthed salamanders are exceptional parents. Salamander moms and dads take turns keeping dozens of little frogs inside their mouths – where the pups are safe from predators and kept warm. The other parent goes out to find food for the kids. This behavior takes a large toll on the parents, because they cannot eat while their children are inside their mouths. As a result, salamanders lose a lot of weight after successfully raising their children.